



Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Wedding in Blood

Wedding in Blood *Les Noces rouges*

Director: Claude Chabrol

Production Companies: Les Films la Boétie,
Canaria Film

Producer: André Génovès

Italian Producer: Virgilio De Blasi *

Production Manager: Pierre Gauchet

Assistant Directors: Michel Dupuy, Alain Wermus

Screenplay: Claude Chabrol

Director of Photography: Jean Rabier

Editors: Jacques Gaillard, Monique Gaillard

Art Director: Guy Littaye

Music: Pierre Jansen

Music Director: André Girard

Sound: Guy Chichignoud, Alex Pront

Cast:

Michel Piccoli (*Pierre Maury*)

Stéphane Audran (*Lucienne Delamare*)

Claude Piéplu (*Paul Delamare*)

Eliana De Santis (*Hélène*)

Clotilde Joano (*Clotilde Maury*)

François Robert (*Inspector Auriol*)

Daniel Lecourtois (*Prefect*)

Pippo Merisi (*Berthier*)

Ermanno Casanova (*town council member*)

Maurice Fourré (*Doctor Bon*)

Philippe Fourré (*prefect's assistant*)

Mme. Pellé (*Clarisse*)

M. Mailley (*Director of C.E.G.*)

Gilbert Servien (*football coach*)

Henri Berger (*billiard player*)

M. Torot (*postman*)

Mme. Meunier (*librarian*)

France-Italy 1973

96 mins

Digital (restoration)

SPOILER WARNING The following notes give away some of the plot.

If Chabrol is to be believed, *Les Noces rouges* is the last film of his Balzacian *comédie humaine* of French society in the middle twentieth century. In this new film, written by Chabrol without the active help of his usual scenarist Paul Gegauff, the bourgeoisie are less charming, less discreet, less intelligent, and far more corrupt than Chabrol has ever before shown them. It was exactly this, no doubt, that caused the French censor to withhold public screenings of the film for over a month. The official reason was that the film might influence the decisions of the jurors in the trial of 'les amants diaboliques de Bourgneuf' then in progress.

It became clear, however, from almost weekly statements by Chabrol, and finally from the film itself after its release, that it was less the verdict of the court which worried the government than the verdict of the voters in the already doubtful April elections. The shape of Chabrol's plot is a classic triangle-murder, owing as much to the tradition of James M. Cain's *The Postman Always Rings Twice* as to press stories about the similar murders in Bourgneuf. One wonders if the censor would have objected in the same way had Chabrol remained faithful to the Bourgneuf affair, setting his tale in a lower social milieu and limiting his plot to an *amour fou*, instead of dealing with political corruption in high government places.

The characters and story, of course, no matter what their ultimate source, are pure Chabrol. His tone and manner are the aciform irony we have come to expect, tempered in (can it be said once again?) the hell of a Langian trap and the revelational – if not redemptive – Hitchcockian confessional. Paul, the mayor of Valençay, a member of the majority party, sexually impotent, deeply vulgar and stupid, although not without a certain political cunning, married Lucienne some years ago, in spite of (or, considering his impotence, because of) her having had an illegitimate daughter. Although Lucienne acts the role of the perfect political wife, listening with seemingly rapt attention to her husband's hopelessly pompous speeches at school theatricals, she and her daughter are 'accomplices' in a constant game of mocking Paul behind his back, joining in laughter at his ludicrous sleeping positions and sonorous snoring.

Paul has a scheme by which he will buy seemingly valueless public land, donate part of it to the town for a park, and use the rest to build cheap housing for the workers who will soon arrive to man a new plastics factory. He needs a partner above any suspicion of political corruption and chooses Pierre, a man above reproach and slightly to the left politically. He begins his seduction of Pierre by asking him to stand for the office of deputy mayor.

Pierre is also married, to Clotilde, a sexually repressed neurotic whose major contribution to her husband's marital happiness is to stock the refrigerator with cold chicken. It is not long, of course, before Pierre and Lucienne are 'les amants fous'. We are not, however, being offered a romantic solution to provincial frustrations. Just as Chabrol parodied the romantic cinema with his swooping tracking shots in the lovers' walk through the poppy fields as long ago as *À double tour*, in *Les Noces rouges* he so controls the love scenes of Pierre and Lucienne that they are as hilarious as they are erotic.

Never having the time for tenderness in their 'stolen hours', the lovers grasp at each other, tearing at each other's clothes, and coupling like cats in extreme heat. This is grand passion reduced to its most banal level. They are made to crawl about in the bushes to retrieve their clothing while it is almost hooked on the lines of passing children out fishing. There is no grace, no style, no charm allowed them; they are merely stupid and vulgar. It is, then, no small achievement that Chabrol, via Stéphane Audran and Michel Piccoli, transforms these characters into people about whom one can care even as one laughs at them. Audran plays her role with the twitching febrility and tempered steel tension of an anxious lioness. Piccoli's

Become a BFI Member

Enjoy a great package of film benefits including priority booking at BFI Southbank and BFI Festivals. Join today at bfi.org.uk/join

Sight and Sound

Never miss an issue with **Sight and Sound**, the BFI's internationally renowned film magazine. Subscribe from just £25*

* Price based on a 6-month print subscription (UK only). More info:

sightandsoundsubs.bfi.org.uk/subscribe

**SIGHT
AND
SOUND**

BFI Player

We are always open online on BFI Player where you can watch the best new, cult & classic cinema on demand. Showcasing hand-picked landmark British and independent titles, films are available to watch in three distinct ways: Subscription, Rentals & Free to view.

See something different today on player.bfi.org.uk

Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Le Beau Serge

Thu 3 Sep 21:00; Sun 20 Sep 15:15 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze)

La Rupture

Fri 4 Sep 18:10; Sat 19 Sep 12:20; Sat 3 Oct 12:10

À double tour

Web of Passion
Sat 5 Sep 14:30; Sat 19 Sep 14:50

The Third Lover

L'oeil du malin
Sat 5 Sep 18:20; Sat 19 Sep 20:45

The Beast Must Die

Que la bête meure
Sat 5 Sep 20:20; Thu 17 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by critic, lecturer and programmer Geoff Andrew);
Sun 4 Oct 18:10

Les Biches

Sun 6 Sep 18:30; Wed 23 Sep 20:40;

Sun 27 Sep 15:00; Mon 5 Oct 14:30

Juste avant la nuit

Just before Nightfall
Tue 8 Sep 20:45; Sun 27 Sep 12:10; Fri 2 Oct 14:30

Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Mon 21 Sep 20:50;
Fri 25 Sep 20:45; Sun 4 Oct 12:20; Tue 6 Oct 14:30

Philosophical Screens: Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 20:10 Blue Room

Wedding in Blood

Les noces rouges
Thu 10 Sep 18:10; Tue 15 Sep 21:00;

Tue 29 Sep 18:20

Ten Days' Wonder

La décade prodigieuse
Thu 10 Sep 20:30 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Sat 19 Sep 18:10

La Femme infidèle

The Unfaithful Wife
From Fri 11 Sep (Preview screening on Tue 1 Sep 20:30)

Violette Nozière

Sun 20 Sep 18:00 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze); Wed 30 Sep 20:30

The Hatter's Ghost

Les fantômes du chapelier
Tue 22 Sep 18:00; Mon 28 Sep 20:35

The Cry of the Owl

Le cri du hibou
Tue 22 Sep 20:55; Mon 28 Sep 18:00

Mean Girls: Claude Chabrol's Dangerous Women

Wed 23 Sep 18:15

The Swindle

Rien ne va plus
Fri 25 Sep 18:15; Sat 3 Oct 18:15 (+ intro by Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

The Colour of Lies

Au coeur du mensonge
Sat 26 Sep 15:00; Sun 4 Oct 15:10

Story of Women

Une affaire de femmes
Sat 26 Sep 17:50; Thu 1 Oct 20:30

La Cérémonie

Thu 1 Oct 18:00 (+ extended intro on queer Chabrol by academic Kit Francis Bradbury Rance);
Tue 6 Oct 20:45

The Bridesmaid

La demoiselle d'honneur
Sat 3 Oct 15:10; Mon 5 Oct 20:40 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley)

The Girl Cut in Two

La fille coupée en deux
Sat 3 Oct 20:40; Tue 6 Oct 18:00 (+ Q&A with Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

With thanks to

Tamasa Distribution

The BFI will be releasing a selection of Claude Chabrol's films on Blu-ray and DVD in 2027

innate sensitivity as an actor works well against the vulgarity of his character, even as he pours wine into his soup to suck the mixture noisily from chunks of soppy bread, so that there are constantly tiny explosions of delight in his performance.

Unable to stand any longer the confines of his frigid marriage, Pierre poisons his wife. While the official reason for Clotilde's death is an accidental overdose, the sensation-hungry townsfolk whisper 'suicide, suicide'. Even Lucienne believes it to be suicide until, in one of the film's most disturbing scenes, Pierre confesses the truth. Until this moment we have been led to believe, by Chabrol's limiting placement of the camera, that Clotilde slept alone in a small, over-decorated room. It is only during the confession that we are shown the entire room, and suddenly realise that they are making love with an added excitement a few feet from Clotilde's deathbed.

Soon Paul, after a quiet dinner, makes his land scheme proposal to Pierre. While Pierre is revolted, he accepts with some reluctance, realising that Paul will have to spend more time in Paris, leaving Lucienne free for himself. Paul, however, perceives that an affair is going on, and instead of going to Paris, waits to trap Lucienne. Far from being displeased, Paul is delighted: he can now trade his wife for Pierre's full co-operation in the swindle. The trapped couple decide to murder the mayor in a staged automobile accident – which is directed by Chabrol in a manner reminiscent of a similar murder in Tay Garnett's version of Cain's *Postman*. Again linking death to the excitement of their passion, Chabrol places the lovers against a background of flames from the burning car for a kiss, with strings of saliva stretched between their mouths, flashing in the light like lines of the web into which they have fallen.

Although to the police there is something patently false about Lucienne's story, they are forced to accept her version of the 'accident'. A phone call from 'M. le Président' orders that there be no further investigation. A scandal is to be avoided at all costs, for what could emerge might be more than a wife's murder of her husband. Thus Chabrol ties political and personal corruption to the highest levels of power.

Ironically, it is this fear of scandal which brings about the final arrest of Pierre and Lucienne. The daughter has suspected that she and her mother are no longer accomplices, that her mother has concealed the affair with Pierre from her. And she chooses to become her stepfather's daughter, a part of the closed and repressive society which has given her legitimacy. She forces a partial confession from her mother – infidelity, not murder – and writes a letter implicating Pierre in the mayor's death. The police cannot ignore it and investigate. Already miserable because of the separation forced on them to divert suspicion, Pierre and Lucienne confess with relief; indeed, Pierre adds gratuitously that he also murdered his wife. Far from being redeemed by their confession, however, they are to be the victims of a further irony. When a detective asks Pierre why he and Lucienne didn't simply leave together to begin anew, without the necessity of accepting hypocrisy, corruption and murder as alternatives, the bewildered response is 'Leave? But we never even dreamed of that!'

In *Les Noces rouges*, as in every film Chabrol has made in the series, which can be extended back as far as *Le Beau Serge*, there is a Paul. This time, however, there is no Hélène or Charles. Chabrol has said that Hélène is partially a creature of myth, and that 'Charles will never kill Paul.' Charles was the character who was incapable of final corruption, who was often an idealist and dreamer. In *Les Noces rouges*, as in the underrated *Doctor Popaul*, it would seem that Paul can be killed by a changed Charles character. The dreamers and the dream, as well as the Hélène of romantic myth, are no more. So it is that Chabrol ends his rich series of bourgeois melodramas. A new sort of system? A new basis for human relationships? Why, they never even dreamed of that!

David L. Overbey, *Sight and Sound*, Autumn 1973